



# Committee Document

**IEC/ISO JSEG 15/WS  
1 N1**

## **Metaverse — Vocabulary**

*Metaverse — Vocabulaire*

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## Foreword

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This document was prepared by ISO/IEC JSEG 15, *Metaverse*.

Any feedback or questions on this document should be directed to the user's national standards body. A complete listing of these bodies can be found at [www.iso.org/members.html](http://www.iso.org/members.html) and [www.iec.ch/national-committees](http://www.iec.ch/national-committees).

## Introduction

This document presents terms and definitions for concepts relevant to the Metaverse.

Specifically, the terminology presented in this document:

- serve as a sound basis in the understanding of Metaverse;
- guide new developments in the field by underpinning mutual understanding; and
- serve as a quick and handy reference for those newly introduced to this field.



# Metaverse — Vocabulary

## 1 Scope

This document provides a concept system and a standard set of terminology related to the Metaverse, from basic concepts to those of the Metaverse ecosystem.

The scope of the vocabulary provided in this document corresponds to that of ISO/IEC JSEG 15.

## 2 Normative references

There are no normative references in this document.

## 3 Terms and definitions

For the purposes of this document, the following terms and definitions apply.

ISO and IEC maintain terminology databases for use in standardization at the following addresses:

- ISO Online browsing platform: available at <https://www.iso.org/obp>
- IEC Electropedia: available at <https://www.electropedia.org>

### 3.1 Metaverse core concepts

#### 3.1.1

##### **metaverse**

*interactive (3.1.15) virtual world (3.1.20) that incorporates spatial referencing (3.1.19) experienced through immersive (3.1.14) technologies*

#### 3.1.2

##### **artificial intelligence**

##### **AI**

capacity of computers or other machines to exhibit or simulate intelligent behavior

[SOURCE: IEEE 7010™-2020]

#### 3.1.3

##### **assistive technology**

piece of equipment, product system, hardware, software or service that is used to enable, maintain or improve functional capabilities of individuals with disabilities

[SOURCE: ITU-T F.791 (08/2018)]

#### 3.1.4

##### **cloud computing**

paradigm for enabling network access to a scalable and elastic pool of shareable physical or virtual resources with self-service provisioning and administration on-demand

[SOURCE: ISO/IEC 17788:2014, 3.2.5]

#### 3.1.5

##### **decentralized identifier**

**DID**

identifier in the format of the W3C Decentralized Identifier

[SOURCE: W3C did-core]

**3.1.6**

**digital human**

realistic virtual human representations created using advanced simulation technology

**3.1.7**

**digital twin**

digital representation of an object of interest

Note 1 to entry: A digital twin may require different capabilities (e.g., synchronization, real-time support) according to the specific domain of application.

[SOURCE: ITU-T Y.4600 (08/2022)]

**3.1.8**

**distributed computing**

model of computing in which a set of nodes coordinates its activities by means of digital messages passed between the nodes

[SOURCE: ISO/IECTR 23188:2020, 3.1.1]

**3.1.9**

**distributed ledger**

a *ledger* ([3.1.18](#)) that is shared across a set of DLT nodes and synchronized between the DLT nodes using a consensus mechanism

[SOURCE: ISO 22739:2024, 3.22]

**3.1.10**

**digital asset**

asset that exists only in digital form or which is the digital representation of another asset

[SOURCE: ISO 24165-1:2021, 3.9]

**3.1.11**

**digital identity**

information used by information systems to represent an external agent, a person, organization, application, or device

**3.1.12**

**edge computing**

*distributed computing* ([3.1.8](#)) in which processing and storage takes place at or near the edge, where the nearness is defined by the system's requirements

[SOURCE: ISO/IECTR 23188:2020, 3.1.3]

**3.1.13**

**edge device**

device that provides an entry point into enterprise or service provider core networks

EXAMPLE Gateways, routers, switches, multiplexers, and a variety of other access devices.

[SOURCE: W3C wot-architecture]

**3.1.14**

**immersive**

creating the illusion of being inside a computer-generated scene



[SOURCE: ISO/IEC19775-1:2023]

### 3.1.15

#### **interactive**

pertaining to a system or mode of operation in which each user entry causes a response from or action by the system

[SOURCE: ISO/IEC/IEEE24765:2017, 3.2050, modified — removed second definition.]

### 3.1.16

#### **Internet of Things**

system of entities (including cyber-physical devices, information resources, and people) that exchange information and interact with the physical world by sensing, processing information, and actuating

[SOURCE: IEEE 2413™-2019, modified — dropped article.]

### 3.1.17

#### **interoperability**

ability of two or more systems or applications to exchange information and to mutually use the information that has been exchanged

[SOURCE: ISO/IEC 17788:2014, 3.1.5]

### 3.1.18

#### **ledger**

information store that keeps records of transactions that are intended to be final, definitive and immutable

[SOURCE: ISO 22739:2024, 3.43]

### 3.1.19

#### **spatial referencing**

method to describe a position within a context

Note 1 to entry: A position may the form of a label, code or coordinate tuple.

Note 2 to entry: Definition modified from ISO 19111:2019, 3.1.56 “spatial reference”.

### 3.1.20

#### **virtual world**

simulated environment that can be accessed by multiple users through an online interface

Note 1 to entry: The simulated environments are often interactive.

Note 2 to entry: The physical world in which people live, and the related characteristics, will be referred to as the “real world” to differentiate it from a virtual world.

[SOURCE: ISO/IEC 27032:2012, 4.51]

### 3.1.21

#### **virtual office**

3-D virtual scene replicating office space of an organization, providing users with an *immersive* ([3.1.14](#)) experience

### 3.1.22

#### **user-generated content**

UGC

content created by users within the *metaverse* ([3.1.1](#))

Note 1 to entry: UGC is often facilitated by simplified editing tools.

## 3.2 Metaverse use cases

### 3.2.1

#### **industrial metaverse**

*metaverse* (3.1.1) that integrates virtual and physical realities to create a sophisticated digital industrial ecosystem, enhancing real-world processes through virtual simulations and strengthening the entire industrial and value chain with increased intelligence, collaboration, openness, service orientation, and interconnectivity

### 3.2.2

#### **financial metaverse**

*metaverse* (3.1.1) enabling a new type of financial business where the physical world and the mirrored digital world are symbiotic

### 3.2.3

#### **education metaverse**

*metaverse* (3.1.1) enabling a multi-sensory *immersive* (3.1.14) classroom connecting virtual and reality, enabling knowledge acquisition, participation, and creation

### 3.2.4

#### **healthcare metaverse**

*metaverse* (3.1.1) that enables the digital, intelligent and accurate medical information platform that breaks space-time restrictions and technical barriers of the original medical system

### 3.2.5

#### **eCommerce metaverse**

*metaverse* (3.1.1) that enables marketing towards users, creating personalized, emotional and social marketing scenes through metaverse technology and content

### 3.2.6

#### **game metaverse**

*metaverse* (3.1.1) that enables the evolution of gaming that embodies four characteristics: immersion, accessibility, accessibility and extensibility

### 3.2.7

#### **social metaverse**

*metaverse* (3.1.1) that creates a holographic virtual reality that integrates the advantages of online and offline social networking, using *AR* (3.3.2), *VR* (3.3.4), *XR* (3.3.1) and other technologies

## 3.3 XR concepts

### 3.3.1

#### **extended reality**

##### **XR**

environments experienced through human-machine sensory interactions commonly composed of real world and virtual elements

Note 1 to entry: Extended reality covers *virtual reality* (3.3.4), *augmented reality* (3.3.2) and *mixed reality* (3.3.3) environments.

### 3.3.2

#### **augmented reality**

##### **AR**

interactive experience of a real-world environment whereby the objects that reside in the real world are augmented by computer-generated perceptual information

[SOURCE: ISO/IEC 18038:2020, 3.1]

### 3.3.3

#### **mixed reality**

**MR**

display continuum in which both real and virtual images are combined in some way and in some proportion

Note 1 to entry: Augmented reality and virtual reality are considered to be on the mixed reality continuum.

[SOURCE: ISO/IECTR 23843:2020, 3.4, modified — added Note 1 to entry.]

**3.3.4**

**virtual reality**

**VR**

artificial environment presented in the computer

[SOURCE: ISO/IECTR 18121:2015, 3.6, modified — dropped article]

**3.3.5**

**mixed reality system**

system that uses a mixture of representations of physical world data and *virtual world* ([3.1.20](#)) data as its presentation medium

[SOURCE: ISO/IEC 18039:2019, 3.1.13]

**3.3.6**

**mixed and augmented reality**

**MAR**

integration of real and virtual worlds including *mixed reality* ([3.3.3](#)) and *augmented reality* ([3.3.2](#))

Note 1 to entry: MAR is often used interchangeably with MR.

[SOURCE: ISO/IEC 18038:2020]

**3.4 Extended metaverse concepts**

**3.4.1**

**C-Meta**

low-carbon social metaverse under the Web 3.0 architecture, aiming to build a new green and energy-saving digital economy

**3.5 Governance**

**3.5.1**

**stakeholder**

role, position, individual, organization, or classes thereof, having an interest, right, share, or claim, in an entity of interest

EXAMPLE End users, operators, acquirers, owners, suppliers, architects, developers, builders, maintainers, regulators, taxpayers, certifying agencies, and markets.

[SOURCE: ISO/IEC/IEEE42010:2022, 3.17, modified — dropped article]

**3.5.2**

**stakeholder perspective**

way of thinking about an entity of interest, especially as it relates to concerns

[SOURCE: ISO/IEC/IEEE42010:2022, 3.18, modified — The original example has been removed.]

**4 Definition of Metaverse**

**4.1 General**

The definition of a “metaverse” has long been subject of controversy.

## 4.2 Approach

In order to define any concept, it is necessary to determine the essential characteristics of the concept, where additions or subtractions to these characteristics will no longer define the concept.

## 4.3 Background

The word “metaverse” originated from the science fiction *Snow Crash* written by Neal Stephenson in 1992 [25].

In popular culture, the term “metaverse” is commonly used as a generalized entity beyond the Internet, as a massively multi-player virtual world experienced through immersive technologies with comprehensive sensory integration through human computer interfaces.

The group has considered a few popular definitions of the “metaverse”, including:

- From [22]: “universal, immersive virtual world that is facilitated by virtual reality (VR) and augmented reality (AR)”
- From [23]: persistent and immersive simulated world that is experienced in the first person by large groups of simultaneous users who share a strong sense of mutual presence
- From [24]: an infinite and persistent set of computer-generated virtual worlds that may be accessed via some human computer interface

## 4.4 Considerations

WS 1 has considered various definitions, common perspectives and expectations on the term “metaverse” and has come to the following conclusions based on consensus.

Essential characteristics of the “metaverse” include:

|             |                                                                                  |
|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| virtual     | as in the items in the experience is virtual                                     |
| immersive   | where it is experienced through human-computer interaction                       |
| spatial     | where the experience is spatially organized according to some notion of location |
| interactive | where users can directly interact with it and receive feedback                   |

Common characteristics expected by popular culture include:

|                      |                                                                            |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| massively multi-user | where there can be many simultaneous users                                 |
| interconnection      | of virtual world systems                                                   |
| interoperability     | between users across virtual world systems                                 |
| persistent           | where actions and events in the virtual world persists after a user leaves |
| real-time            | where user actions are performed in real-time                              |

## 4.5 Consensus

The resulting consensus arrived at this definition for “metaverse”:

metaverse: interactive virtual world that incorporates spatial referencing experienced through immersive technologies

**Annex A**  
(informative)

**Abbreviated terms**

|     |                                        |
|-----|----------------------------------------|
| AGI | artificial general intelligence        |
| AI  | artificial intelligence                |
| API | application programming interface      |
| AR  | augmented reality                      |
| DLT | distributed ledger technology          |
| IoT | Internet of Things                     |
| ML  | machine learning                       |
| OMF | Open Modeling Foundation               |
| OWL | Web Ontology Language                  |
| RDF | Resource Description Framework         |
| UDT | Urban Digital Twin                     |
| VR  | virtual reality                        |
| WoT | Web of Things                          |
| W3C | World Wide Web Consortium              |
| XR  | collective reference to both AR and VR |

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